

I taught them the trick. It still worked on them.

PERSUASION SPOTTER

A short lesson in noticing persuasion while it's still happening.

FOR AGES 12 TO 18

Why didn't knowing the trick stop it from working?

We were talking about hooks. Specifically, why we call them hooks.

A fisher picks the bait for a particular fish, in a particular stretch of river, at a particular time of day. Nobody throws something in the water and hopes. The first two seconds of a video work the same way. Somebody chose that, for someone, on purpose.

My students understood it immediately. They could watch a video and tell me what the hook was and who it was cast for.

Then the video ended, the next one started on its own, and they kept watching.

They could name the bait and still not look up.

Not because they forgot the lesson. Because naming happens afterward, and afterward is too late to decide anything.

The order goes like this:

- 01** Something happens outside you.
- 02** Something changes inside you.
- 03** You feel pulled toward doing something.
- 04** You do it.

The name shows up at step five. That's a fine place for a name. It's a useless place for a defense.

So this lesson works on step two. Not the word. The feeling. The half-second where something lands and part of you leans in.

Does noticing make you immune? No. Nothing does. Not my students, not me, not the person who made the video.

But half a second is enough to ask one question, and a question is all reasoning ever needed.

Researchers separate having persuasion knowledge from using it. Campbell and Kirmani (2000), in the Journal of Consumer Research, found that people who had the knowledge failed to apply it when their attention was occupied and the seller's motive wasn't obvious. What I watched in my classroom was that gap. Whether noticing the feeling closes it is what I'm still testing.

The six moves

- 01 Notice the tell.**
What did you catch yourself doing?
- 02 Name the pull.**
What was underneath it?
- 03 Find the trigger.**
What exactly caused it?
- 04 Make the move.**
Do something physical with it. Cover it, set it down, say it out loud. Then look again.
- 05 Ask one question.**
One is enough.
- 06 Give a verdict.**
Including the verdict that nothing was wrong.

The worksheet adds one line above these, for writing down what you saw and where. Everything after that is the six moves.

Here they are on something small

A game puts a banner on the home screen. *Season ends in 2 days.*

THE TELL

I opened the app to check. I hadn't planned to open the app.

THE PULL

Hurry.

THE TRIGGER

Not the items. The number 2.

THE MOVE

Thumb over the countdown. What's left is a set of skins I looked at last week and felt fine about walking away from.

THE QUESTION

Would I want these if they were here all month?

THE VERDICT

The deadline is real, and the game isn't lying to me about that. I like playing it. I'll use the thing. I'm buying it on purpose.

That last line is the one people skip.

Running the six moves isn't a method for talking yourself out of things. A lot of the time you'll look closely and say yes anyway. The difference is that you decided.

What it feels like from the inside

Each one leads with the feeling, because the feeling is what you'll meet first. The name is at the bottom, which is where it belongs. Not everyone feels all five, and not every time.

HURRY

"This has to be decided today."

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Countdowns. Only 3 left. Ends tonight. Spots are filling. A price that goes up at midnight.

The move. Cover the timer or the number with your thumb. Read the offer again.

ASK Would I still want this tomorrow?

marketers call this: scarcity, urgency

LEFT OUT

"Everyone already has this and I'm the one standing outside."

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

View counts. Sold-out sizes. Ten million users. A comment section agreeing with itself.

The move. Cover the number. Does the thing still look good with nobody standing next to it?

ASK Do I want this, or do I want to be where everyone else is?

marketers call this: social proof

IMPRESSED

"They know more than I do, so I should probably stop asking."

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Titles. Lab coats. Initials after a name. Doctor recommended. A study nobody links to. A very large following.

The move. Say the credential out loud and finish two sentences. "Expert in _____. "And I know that because _____."

ASK Expert in what, and how would I check?

marketers call this: authority

OBLIGATED

"They gave me something. It would be rude to walk away now."

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Free samples. Free trials. A discount code you didn't ask for. A gift with purchase. Someone who was very nice to you first.

The move. Put the free thing down. Actually set it down, close the tab, hand back the sample. Then decide.

ASK Would I choose this if they hadn't given me anything first?

marketers call this: reciprocity

SEEN

"This isn't an ad. This is a description of me."

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

For the girls who. Quiz results. Aesthetic labels. If you know, you know. A horoscope that lands.

The move. Cross out the group and write in one you don't belong to. If it still fits, it was never about you.

ASK Do I want the thing, or the version of me that comes with it?

marketers call this: identity appeals, in-group signaling

**Something can be true of you
without being unique to you.**

Three specimens

Work these in order. The last question is the one everybody wants to answer first, and answering it first is how you end up with a vocabulary quiz instead of a skill.

1. What changed in you while you read it?
2. What exactly caused that?
3. What does it want you to do?
4. What question would slow the decision down?
5. Now name the pull.

ONE

LIMITED EDITION ART KIT

17 people are viewing this right now

Only a few left. Once they're gone, they're gone.

TWO

SPRING SHOWCASE TICKETS

The auditorium seats 240.

31 seats left for Friday. 96 left for Saturday.

Sales close Thursday at 3pm so we can print the programs.

THREE · A TEXT FROM A FRIEND

ok you're the last person who hasn't watched it

we are all talking about it at lunch tomorrow

i'm not going to be able to not spoil it

After all three

Two of these are asking you to hurry. Only one of them can be checked. The art kit page never says how many kits were made or how many are left. Limited out of what? Seventeen people viewing right now, according to whom? A claim you can't test isn't information, it's atmosphere.

Your friend is absolutely using social pressure on you, and there's nothing wrong with it. The verdict here is allowed to be "yes, and I'm glad."

Hunt in the wild

Catch five. Write up the three that surprised you most.

You aren't looking for ads. You're looking for the moment something in you moves. That can happen anywhere.

A video that kept you watching after you meant to stop. A checkout page. A cereal box. A poster in a hallway. A group chat. A teacher. A church. A friend who's very good at picking restaurants. Your own head, talking you into something at eleven at night.

Two rules

At least one write-up has to end in "that was fair and I went along with it on purpose." If they all come back suspicious, you've stopped noticing and started hunting, and those are different activities.

You aren't grading the world. You're collecting moments you caught.

One thing to expect

For the first few, you'll notice on the way home, or an hour later, or while filling out the sheet. That still counts. Catching it afterward is how everyone starts. Catching it while it's happening comes later, and it comes from doing this more than once.

The five you caught

One line each. Enough to remember it by. Star the three you'll write up.

01 _____

02 _____

03 _____

04 _____

05 _____

SEND ME THE GOOD ONE

I'd like to see it. hello@brookereports.com. I'm building the full course out of real examples, and the ones students catch are better than the ones I go looking for.

Spot the Pull

NAME

DATE

One message per sheet. You aren't hunting villains. Plenty of persuasion is fair, and some of it's doing you a favor. You're looking for the moment something shifted, so you can decide what to do about it on purpose.

01 THE MESSAGE

What did you see or hear, and where did you find it?

02 THE TELL

What did you catch yourself doing?

- ☐ Wanted to decide right now ☐ Went back to look again ☐ Checked who else had it
☐ Started explaining why it was fine ☐ Reached for my phone or wallet ☐ Other: _____

03 THE PULL

Now the feeling underneath it.

- ☐ Hurry ☐ Left out ☐ Impressed ☐ Obligated ☐ Seen ☐ Other: _____

04 THE TRIGGER

The exact words, number, or image that did it. Quote it.

05 THE MOVE

Cover it, set it down, say it out loud. Then look again. What is left?

06 THE QUESTION

One question you could ask before you decide anything.

07 THE VERDICT

- ☐ Fair, and I'm going along with it on purpose ☐ Reasonable, but I want another look
☐ Not enough information yet ☐ Pushier than it needed to be